

The APAPDC

L5

School leadership frame: an Indigenous focus

The APAPDC L5 frame for building leadership in schools is based on five propositions about leadership development and how leadership capability is built.

1. **Leadership** starts from within
2. **Leadership** is about influencing others
3. **Leadership** develops a rich learning environment
4. **Leadership** builds professionalism and management capability
5. **Leadership** inspires leadership actions and aspirations in others

The frame can be used as an audit tool to assist school leaders to consider their leadership and also identify areas in which they can work more strategically.

The Indigenous focus of the frame has not only been written for school leaders of Indigenous students — it is for all school leaders who are committed to promoting Reconciliation and Indigenous perspectives within their school.

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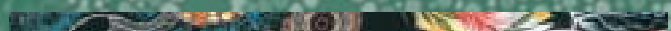
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Leaders
Lead



Dare to Lead



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L5 1



Leadership starts from within

Key themes: *Beliefs, Values, Integrity, Knowledge, Responsibility, Commitment, Courage, Resilience*

Leaders committed to Indigenous perspectives:

1. Value and acknowledge Indigenous culture
2. Have a strong commitment to improving outcomes for Indigenous students
3. Continue to explore their own feelings about racism, social justice and equity
4. Are honest about their own beliefs and attitudes towards Indigenous Australians
5. Understand that leadership in Indigenous education requires sensitivity, persistence and belief in their ability to make a real difference
6. Are aware of the perceptions and beliefs held by the Indigenous community about the title and role of the Principal

L5 2



Leadership is about influencing others

Key themes: *Power, Relationships, Communication, Respect, Expectations, Politics, Trust, Advocacy*

Leaders committed to Indigenous perspectives:

1. Listen to and act on Indigenous community input
2. Build quality relationships within the school community
3. Work strategically with the knowledge that relationships within and between the school and Indigenous community can be complex
4. Promote the importance of protocols such as Acknowledgement of Country, Respect for Elders, flying Indigenous flags, and inviting Indigenous representatives into the school; and events such as Reconciliation Week and NAIDOC Week
5. Develop communication skills and processes that are respectful, engaging, and inclusive of their local Indigenous community
6. Model inclusive practices
7. Are aware that in addition to inviting Indigenous parents and families into the school, leaders need to go out into the Indigenous community and connect with community members on their terms
8. Establish an effective collegial network
9. Ensure that Indigenous education is the responsibility of all school staff — not only Indigenous staff

L5 3



Leadership develops a rich learning environment

Key themes: *Intellect, Reflection, Facilitation, Teaching, Openness, Evidence, Collaboration*

Leaders committed to Indigenous perspectives:

1. Build the capacity of all staff and students to develop an informed understanding of Australia's Indigenous peoples and cultures, and the importance of the Reconciliation process
2. Actively promote contact between Indigenous and non-Indigenous staff and students
3. Employ Indigenous staff in a range of responsibilities across the school
4. Understand Indigenous students will learn better when they experience a holistic 'whole-student approach'* to health and wellbeing. This is comprised of:
 - respectful and caring relationships
 - high but achievable expectations
 - opportunities for authentic participation and contribution
5. Build the capacity of staff to address the specific learning and wellbeing needs of their students
6. Support the role of parents and families as the primary educators of their children and the importance of family/school/community partnerships
7. Understand that curriculum activities centred on Indigenous culture need to be handled sensitively and positively
8. Encourage the development of a whole school curriculum that includes Indigenous perspectives
9. Value the life experiences that their Indigenous students bring to school

* For further information refer to the *Community Matters: Working with diversity for wellbeing* booklet from the MindMatters kit

L5 4



Leadership builds professionalism and management capability

Key themes: *Service, Accountability, Excellence, Ethics, Professional advocacy*

Leaders committed to Indigenous perspectives:

1. Ensure that the management of the school is underpinned by values such as quality of relationships, commitment to equity and social justice and respect for others
2. Provide formal feedback to staff and the school board/council about school performance in relation to Indigenous student outcomes in attendance, student retention and academic performance

3. Encourage networking opportunities for their staff with staff from other schools with Indigenous students
4. Are vigilant in keeping up with current Indigenous education trends, issues and plans
5. Encourage all staff to set performance goals and targets for personal growth and professional development related to Indigenous cultural awareness and Indigenous student achievement
6. Are active members of the *Dare to Lead* coalition
7. Ensure that their school's Indigenous Education plan is a part of their school's Strategic Plan and promotes improved outcomes for Indigenous students by:
 - Developing clear and realistic but also challenging targets for improvements for their Indigenous students
 - Developing school action plans for Indigenous education which define tasks, assign responsibilities and establish timelines
 - Identifying the resources necessary to support improvement and committing to a budget for this
 - Seeking advice from sources beyond the school if required
 - Collecting data about what is really happening within the school and using this as a basis for monitoring progress
 - Documenting and celebrating successes
 - Utilising the *Dare to Lead* project and its partner resources as a guide in detailing the above
8. Clearly articulate and document the school's directions and priorities in Indigenous education

L5 5

Leadership inspires leadership actions and aspirations in others

Key themes: *Encouragement, Risk, Opportunities, Mentoring, Coaching, Modelling*

Leaders committed to Indigenous perspectives:

1. Invite Indigenous community role models into the school to motivate and challenge all staff, students, parents and families
2. Value and celebrate all staff achievements in the area of Indigenous education
3. Provide opportunities for all staff to increase their knowledge of Indigenous history and culture by engaging with relevant cultural learnings
4. Mentor or provide mentors for all potential leaders
5. Provide a supportive environment where risk-taking is acceptable and 'mistakes' are seen as learning opportunities
6. Embrace Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander leadership

Workshop discussion starters

Proposition 1

Acknowledging the traditional owners of your area

1. *It is the first time that you have invited an Indigenous Elder to the school assembly to perform a Welcome to Country. After the assembly you are criticised by a parent for inviting the wrong person.*
 - How would you respond in the first instance?
 - What would you do next and who would you engage in this process?
 - Would you do anything differently in the future?

Proposition 2

Engaging parents and connecting with the community

2. *You have just attended a meeting with the outgoing principal of your new school. He/she complains about the unwillingness of Indigenous parents to attend school assemblies, performances, parents' nights or school council meetings.*

The outgoing principal concluded their 'handover' session with you by advising that all meetings with the local Indigenous community should be held on school grounds.

 - What historical/cultural issues might you need to address?
 - How would you address this situation as the new principal?

Resentment of non-Indigenous parents due to perceived favouritism

3. *Your P & C president voices general community concerns about the preferential treatment given to the Indigenous students in your school.*
 - What is your immediate response?
 - How would you address the situation with members of the broader community?
 - To what extent do issues of this nature provide you with opportunities to create a more harmonious school community?

Proposition 3

Understanding resilience in Indigenous communities

4. *The MindMatters mental health secondary school initiative used the metaphor of a 'Strength Tree' * as a basis for exploring the things that Indigenous students and school staff believed help Indigenous students to be resilient.*
 - How does your school contribute to the development of resilience in its Indigenous students?
 - What stops young people from being strong or resilient?
 - How does a lack of resilience impact on student learning?



* For information about 'The Strong Tree' which was further developed by the Iwantja school and community in South Australia refer to: <http://cms.curriculum.edu.au/mindmatters/atsi/strengthtree.htm>

Developing a welcoming environment for Indigenous parents and families

5. *Invitations for Indigenous parents and families to attend activities at the school are sent out regularly through the school newsletter but no one comes!*

- *Why is this so?*
- *How would you create an environment where Indigenous parents and families feel welcome and are involved on a regular basis?*

Cultural understanding

6. *Mary is appointed as principal to a remote school. She has had no previous experience with Indigenous people or Indigenous culture.*

In her first week, three Indigenous students from one family display violent behaviour and she suspends them in line with mandatory policy. There is a strong community backlash, which has led to complaints of racism being made to the district office.

- *Did Mary do the right thing?*
- *How can Mary build a relationship with the community?*
- *What steps could Mary take next time a similar incident occurs?*

Developing a rich learning environment

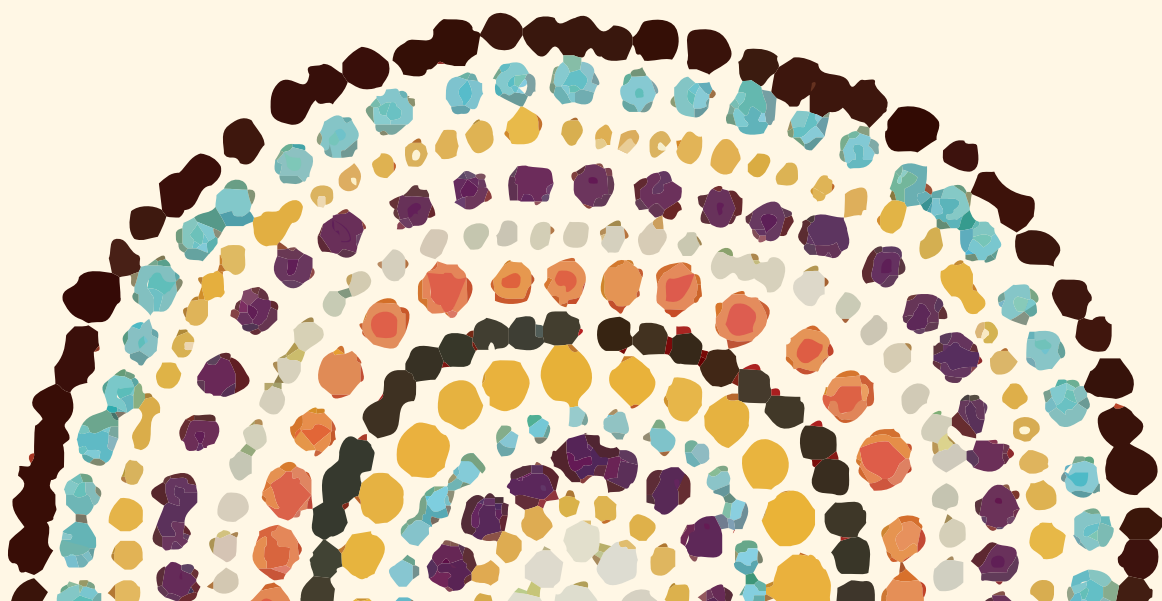
7. *Your Deputy Principal comes to you after collecting all of the school's teaching programs and comments about the lack of Indigenous perspectives across curriculum areas.*

- *What processes would you put in place to ensure an Indigenous perspective across key learning areas?*
- *Who should be involved in this process?*

Developing a rich learning environment

8. *A member of the School Executive is concerned at the large number of Indigenous students who fall in the lower band of achievement in numeracy and literacy. She has gathered strong support from her staff and colleagues for the implementation of a remedial 'withdrawal focused' curriculum for these students. Your Indigenous Education Worker has expressed strong reservations about this planned program.*

- *What are the implications of this planned program?*
- *What might be the reservations of the Indigenous Education Worker?*
- *How would you resolve this situation?*



Proposition 4

Management of the school

9. *John, a new principal at the school, sees that the previous principal has spent \$10,000 from the main school budget on a literacy program that employs local Elders. John cuts this line of funding without consulting anyone. The local community complain to the District Director who asks John to come for a meeting in his office with the local AECG President.*
- *What would you do if you were John?*
 - *How would you prepare for the meeting if you were John?*
 - *How can this situation be resolved?*
 - *What are the implications for Indigenous students and the Indigenous community in the removal of this project?*

Professional development of staff

10. *Your school's Indigenous Education Worker has completed his teaching degree and been appointed to your school in a teaching role. The staff who have worked with him in the past do not believe he has the skills necessary to be a good teacher, and bring their concerns to you.*
- *How would you respond to the concerns of your staff?*
 - *How will you manage the induction of this 'new' teacher?*

Professional development of staff

11. *An Indigenous Teacher is selected as your new Assistant Principal through the normal merit selection processes. Her CV did not indicate her Aboriginality. Upon commencement of her duties as Assistant Principal she takes a strong lead role in Indigenous education. Staff and community members raise several concerns about her ability to do the job.*
- *What concerns could staff have?*
 - *What concerns could the community have?*
 - *How, as Principal, would you address both staff and community concerns, and support the welfare of the Assistant Principal?*

Proposition 5

Inspiring leadership actions in others

12. *The District has implemented a reward ceremony for students and staff who have achieved excellence in Indigenous leadership programs. You have nominated two Indigenous students and one staff member. At a staff meeting, teachers raise their concern that this process is 'reverse racism' and they wish the school to have nothing to do with it.*
- *What are the significant issues in this scenario?*
 - *What are the benefits and what are the difficulties in recognising Indigenous students for their achievements in this way?*
 - *How can you address staff concerns?*



APAPDC

The APAPDC is the national professional development body owned by the four Australian peak principals' associations — the Australian Secondary Principals Association, Australian Primary Principals Association, Association of Principals of Catholic Secondary Schools of Australia and Association of Heads of Independent Schools of Australia. It is governed by a Board representing these four associations, and managed by a secretariat based in Adelaide.

Dare to Lead



...making the difference

Dare to Lead (www.daretolead.edu.au)

Dare to Lead is a national program working with school leaders to improve the educational outcomes of Indigenous students. Close to 5000 schools and 200 educational organisations across Australia have signed up to be members of the *Dare to Lead* coalition. As coalition members they are committed to:

- Improving educational outcomes for Indigenous students
- Promoting cultural understanding
- Supporting the goals of Reconciliation

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A companion document — ***The L5 frame: How do school leaders demonstrate the L5 propositions?*** — has been developed to be used in conjunction with this booklet and further explores the propositions and what they mean for school leaders. This document has been workshopped in *Dare to Lead* professional development sessions and can be downloaded from the 'Professional development' section of the *Dare to Lead* website.

Workshop discussion starters/scenarios have been developed with a particular focus on 'Remote schools' and 'Aboriginal leadership' and these scenarios can also be downloaded from the 'Professional development' section of the *Dare to Lead* website.

School leaders are encouraged to explore other practical leadership materials and activities through the **Same Kids Same Goals** toolkit at: www.samekidssamegoals.dsf.org.au